the company in 2010 ‘positioned India as a strategic area in its medium-term management plan’.

Ratan is a strong votary of inclusion and universalism, believing that the quality of people’s lives has to be improved, irrespective of their nationalities or their citizenships. He has often repeated this strong commitment when Tata companies acquired businesses in India, the US, the UK and Africa. He reiterated this priority after he and Tata officials met Thabo Mbeki, the deputy president of the Republic of South Africa, along with the officials of the Tata Group in 1996. During his visit to the country, he was struck by the wide disparity between the rich and the poor and it was an important motivation for him to help the nation. On his return to India, he wrote to Mbeki echoing his desire thus: ‘I have a strong desire to participate in the development and empowerment of the people of South Africa. I believe that we in Tatas would like to be different from other industrial groups by focussing our attention on areas which would supplement your efforts to improve the quality of life of your people—rather than merely to exploit the resources of your nation. In short, I would like to have the Tata Group undertake activities whereby they can be remembered for what they gave to, rather than what they took from South Africa.’

He reiterated this commitment on several occasions. He had also told Nelson Mandela when he met him, ‘I wish we could put something in South Africa rather than take it out.’ Ratan admired the South African leader for the struggle he had waged against apartheid. On his death, Ratan tweeted that, ‘The world has lost a great leader. Nelson Mandela was the father of a free South Africa where all people had equal rights. He will be missed.’

After Mbeki became President in 1999, he created an International Investment Council with thirteen members who had already accepted the invitation. The council was important as he drew ‘heavily on [its] business advice in formulating policy’. Besides Ratan, the members included his good friend Minoru Makihara and George Soros, chairperson of the Soros Fund Management. After his nomination in April of the year, Ratan wrote to Mbeki: ‘I have a great feeling of attraction for South Africa and I have a strong desire to make whatever contribution I can to improve the quality of life of the people of South Africa without any act of exploitation.’

Ratan’s association with Mbeki strengthened over the years and they became friends corresponding regularly. Mbeki stepped down from the